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Robert Moore

Life story interview with Paul Thompson

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Principle investigator's thematic highlights

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Table of Contents

1: Transgenerational masculinity 3
2: Politics and intellectuality in a working class family 3
3: Home owners and upward mobility 4
4: Gender and confiding with parents 5
5: Influence of an only childhood 6
6: In the Royal Navy: social class and self-confidence 6
7: Religion: the influence of George McLeod of Iona 8
8: Peter Worsley as mentor 8
9: Hull, a political hot-bed 9
10: Stuck in the library 10
11: Working with John Rex 11
12: Framing questions: Malinowski 12
13: Participant observation in an ethnically mixed community 13
14: Marginal men as a source for theory 18
15: The power of Durham women 20
16: Spotting community myth 21
17: Divided community: Peterhead 22
18: Discrimination against women: the oil industry 24

Robert Moore

Interviewed by Paul Thompson

20 September 2011, 23 February 2012

1: Transgenerational masculinity

It never occurred to me that other people's fathers might not help them with their algebra homework, or that they were not good at woodwork, electrical work, bricklaying, and so on. My grandfather – my father's father – had a little workshop in the garden where he made toys and did odds and ends. My father had a workshop, and he did all the household maintenance and lots of other work, including making me a model aeroplane that I could sit in, and it had a propeller driven by a wind-up gramophone motor! And then I have always had a workshop, and I do all the household maintenance, and a certain amount of carpentry and joinery and I enjoy that. And sometimes a little bit of metalwork or whatever. My son has the most eye-watering workshop in his village in South Tyrol – with the kind of equipment that you would normally expect to see in a professional place. So there's four generations of workshops running down the male side of my family, and it never occurred to me that people didn't have workshops, it was just a part of the house. (p. 1)

2: Politics and intellectuality in a working class family

My mother was an extremely intelligent woman, and I think had she been born, say, in 1938 rather than 1908, she would probably have become a professor of English literature or something like that, instead of which she went into service as a girl. She was a red-hot Socialist. My father was a very staunch Labour Party worker and Trade Union local Branch Official…

Now, interestingly, when we were - during the War, we used to listen, in the shelter, to things on the radio, and I remember Churchill, some of those famous speeches "We shall fight them on the beaches" and things, my parents would say, "Good old Winnie!"! So I

thought they really loved Churchill. And after the War, I discovered they absolutely despised him, and he stood for everything that they absolutely hated, but because he was the War leader, they supported him. The other thing my parents taught me, or tried to impose upon me, was deep distrust of the police – all policemen were on the take. And they could give you examples, bribery and corruption and so on. (pp. 2-3)

You were saying how you would listen to Churchill, as a family, would you debate about politics and social things.

Very much so. Now, the Beveridge Report was, what, 1944. Now, you think, I was eight. My parents and I discussed the *Beveridge Report* in the shelter. Now, I don't suppose many people who, at the age of eight, were discussing the *Beveridge Report*, and how things were going to be better after the War…

My father, he didn't hate the bosses, but he hated the bosses who adopted certain attitudes. For example, if a boss called him "Mr. Moore", or "Doug" or "Pony", that was fine, but sometimes the boss would say, "Moore", and he absolutely hated that, and he would say, "I'm Mr. Moore, please". And he was very dismissive of some of the managers because he taught them their jobs and found that they didn't know things like how to work out decimals and so on. And then, you know, two years later, they turned up telling him what to do. So he was a very staunch Union man, and so all those things fed into a very class-conscious politics, and very very strong support for Labour.

I mean, that burnt in my mother. I remember, at the height of the Thatcher era, my mother, who would then have been, I suppose in her seventies, saying, "What's wrong with all the young men in Britain today? No guts!" She said, "If I had a gun, I'd go out and kill her!" I'm not sure how serious she was! I mean, she really hated Thatcher. (pp. 5-6)

3: Home owners and upward mobility

My parents, by contrast, when they were married in 1933, bought a house. And again, that makes an unusual - my father, a kind of skilled worker, buying a house, £500, brand new, in Beckenham. They had a 20 year mortgage, it cost them £1,000 when they paid

for it. So again I assumed they were just an ordinary family, but that wasn't quite ordinary. And up and down the street we had people of very similar social status – there were people who worked in the print in Fleet Street; there were bank workers; school teachers. An example of my mother's humour, you know, she would look out of the window and see, say, a man from up the road, going to get the train, carrying his brief case, and she'd say, "Oh yeah, there he goes with his brief case! He's got marmalade sandwiches in those!" She didn't like sort of people with airs and graces, so brief cases meant marmalade sandwiches! So as I say, we lived in this street of owner-occupied houses, which was new. Most of the people, or most of the young people – my peers in that street – would have been part of that very upwardly-mobile generation of people who benefited from the extension of Local Government/Welfare State education, etc., etc.. I'm not one of those people that goes back to School Reunions, but my research assistant actually married a bloke who turned out be the son of one of my schoolmates! And so I went to the wedding and caught up on some of the "old boys" as it were. And it was very boring! They'd become bank managers and so on. (p. 4)

4: Gender and confiding with parents

Early in life, to my mother. There was nothing I couldn't talk to her about. When I was a young teenager, when I had my first girlfriend and so on, and she said, "You do know all about girls, don't you? How they work and so on?" I said, "Yeah, I think I do". And she was quite happy to talk about sex with me. My father was much more reticent and shy about that sort of thing. I could talk to him about building radio sets and making mortise joints, but my mother, I could talk about sex and anything really about family. She would talk about it, she wasn't pompous about it, she'd joke about it as well.

But in their latter years, I think I became much closer to my father. He became much more of a mate, and the interesting thing was to see how our roles changed. He would ask me for advice on things, you know, about pensions and those practical difficult things as you get older. But occasionally I would phone him up and say, "I've got a problem with this thing I'm making, how would you make this joint?" And he would tell me on the phone. We would talk about those sort of practical things. (p. 7)

5: Influence of an only childhood

I was the only child, and in the Wartime, you didn't go out playing on the streets, they were perfectly nice kids in the street, and occasionally one did, but there were all the problems of air raids and so on, so we mainly stayed at home. I was on my own at home, and didn't have any brothers and sisters, so I think I became quite a self-contained solitary person, and I think that influenced much of my later life. I loved books, I read lots - when other children, my cousins were reading Enid Blyton, I was reading history books. My wife says, "You were never a child". I read books, I love music, I used to go to the museums. I went to the 1948 and '49 Promenade Concert Season, and I used to join the queue for the Promenade – I was probably the youngest person in the queue! We used to keep one another's place in the queue so that people could go away. I used to go to the Science Museum, or the Geological Museum in my break from the queue, and I used to go to Beckenham Public Library and read. My parents bought me books - my father was a great man for Foyle's Bookshop, and he was always bringing me - in fact, he chose the most wonderful books for me to read. I've still got a lot of those books, with the dates written in them, you know, "1943", 1944", with black and white illustrations. That really was how I grew up. (p. 8)

6: In the Royal Navy: social class and self-confidence

I wouldn't haven't missed [the Navy] for anything. I came out of the Navy for a number of reasons, one of which was, when Polaris came in, I just simply wasn't prepared to countenance nuclear weapons in any circumstances. So I rejected, if you like, the culture and everything the Navy stood for. <u>But</u> it was really quite fantastic for me. I could go on forever about this, but in terms of building my own self-confidence, in giving me all sorts of professional skills – which was the basis of one's self-confidence - travel, for Heaven's sake, I went about twice round the world, in distance, when I was in the Navy! … Because there was this solitary little boy, who'd come from a very sheltered background in many ways, who really got out into the world and faced many challenges …

When I went to Dartmouth, I suddenly discovered all these public schoolboys, and I wondered where I was! I mean, they were all so juvenile! And they had water fights, and

de-bagging, and I thought, "Who are these children!" Then suddenly I realised that theirs was the dominant culture, and I was the outsider. When we all arrived, people immediately started, "Where were you at school?" "Oh", you know, "Wellington", "Pangbourne", "Westminster", "Eton". "Oh, do you know so and so?" And everybody had friends and acquaintances, and perhaps some of them knew one another's fathers, they had Naval backgrounds, or military backgrounds. And people said to me, "Where were you at school?" I said, "Beckenham and Penge County Grammar School for Boys", and the conversation kind of flagged, at that point! So that was a very strange experience for me.

I suppose partly because of my mother and the kind of repartee that went on in the family, I was very prone to make kind of ironic comments and so on, and irony didn't go down terribly well at Dartmouth. I remember, particularly, we were being told - when you were waiting for classes, you fell in outside the classroom, and you stood at ease, but if any officers came by, you had to come to attention, and the class leader had to salute. And they said, "if any of the officers' wives come, you have to do the same salute". Now, the Commander at Dartmouth had a dog, it was a golden retriever, you see, so they're giving us all this briefing, and I said, "If the Commander's dog comes past, do we have to salute as well?" And they said, "Don't be such an idiot!" … It was just completely lost on them, that this was a deeply ironic comment on hierarchy in the Navy! I constantly put my foot in it like that. …

My last ship was a very small ship, and I was the First Lieutenant of that, and I commanded it very briefly. And that was wonderful. … She was 100 tonnes, a hundred feet long, and a crew of about 26/27. A very good sea boat. The *Aberford*. I absolutely loved that ship – if one can love an inanimate object! Sometimes on watch, I would talk to her, I remember! I suppose a kind of madness takes you! But some of my nicest moments, some of the best moments in a way, in my life perhaps, were those quiet moments on watch, in the middle of the night, or very early, perhaps on the morning watch, you were just alone on the bridge, or maybe alone, and just a couple of lookouts posted, because in those days, all the ships had open bridges, you didn't have these sort of glass enclosed things when you were on the bridge, either in your polo-neck sweater and duffel coat, or in your oilskin, depending on the weather, and you were just quietly there,

plunging along through the sea, and all seemed quiet in the world, and the ship was humming under you, and you knew that all these people on shore, including your parents and girlfriends and so on, they were all fast asleep, and you were there out on the ocean….

What would I have been - 23, 24? - driving a ship worth Heaven knows how much money, I suppose the ship was worth about £1m., and a crew of 25, and there you were in charge – driving the thing across the ocean! I mean, that does things for you. That was the very strange thing of going to university and suddenly finding myself in the back row of a lecture, and nobody gave two hoots whether I was there or not, whereas just a few months before, there were 25 men hanging on a decision that I made. (pp. 13-15)

7: Religion: the influence of George McLeod of Iona

I'd made friends in Northern Ireland, women friends, interestingly enough, and really become quite attached to Londonderry, for all its problems. Of course, I became very aware of the problems, and the religion thing. I should make a comment about religion. I mentioned Lawrence Burton [my naval tutor at Greenwich], but the other person who was very influential on me was George McLeod of the Iona Community. I regard George as the greatest Scotsman of the 20th century. He was, I think, an inspiration to everybody who came in contact with him. I really loved him. And he was so kind and supportive to me. He'd been in the Army in the First World War, had got the MC at Gallipoli, and, of course, he was a really militant Pacifist, and a big noise in CND. He never challenged me, he just talked the issues through with me, because he knew I had to make my mind up, and he adopted a very kind of paternal role towards me. He even offered to give me money, to help me to get out of the Navy, which was lovely of him, but I didn't need it. And, of course, his books, and his preaching and so on, and his role in the Peace Movement was something that really inspired me, and hardened my resolve, that I really did have to get out of [the Navy]. (p. 18)

8: Peter Worsley as mentor

[At the suggestion of Lawrence Burton] I did go to see Peter Worsley. Peter Worsley was at Hull University. So I flew to my interview from Northern Ireland. So I was in the Navy and I was expecting to meet some sort of grey-bearded professor, and I was met by this very young man at the bus station in Cottingham, who was wearing a blue and white striped T-shirt, and he greeted me, and said, "You're Robert Moore?" … He was very active in CND, and we just - Peter and I hit it off, and I didn't decide there and then to go to Hull, but he made it pretty clear that should I so decide, there would be no problem. He wrote to me on and off… Then I took the plunge and resigned my commission. …

One could see that he was both a political and an academic figure, and that these were one. There was no separation, if you like, between who he was – his politics and his scholarship. Of course, he was primarily, by training and inclination, an anthropologist, so I got a very good grounding … [but] I think my great debt to Peter is to introduce me to the work of C. Wright-Mills, to whom I have constantly returned, and to some extent, although John Rex is more important in this respect, the work of Max Weber. Peter was just lively and friendly, and funny, and very very knowledgeable, and it was just a joy to write essays for him. … I just loved being in his tutorials and listening to him talking. …

But Peter was always there in the background, a very inspirational figure. And I've made contact with him recently, and had a bit of correspondence with him, having read his recent autobiography. And it turns out that he lived, as a child, near where I now live, and he hopes to come up sometime to go to some of his childhood haunts. So Peter was my bridge from the Navy to academia. (pp. 17-21)

9: Hull, a political hot-bed

I don't think I could have gone anywhere better than Hull. It was a hotbed of Left-wing activity, but it wasn't just that, it was a hotbed of Left-wing scholars. I think the *Daily Express* used to publish, every year, a list of the ten most dangerous people in Britain, and I think three of the teachers at Hull were in the top five! I mean, that was enough to recommend it to anybody! If the *Daily Express* thought they were dangerous, they had to be good! …

[John Saville's] knowledge of English social history and his take on it was marvellous… John had been involved in the demobilisation mutinies in India… When the Cyprus issue was really blowing up – and I had, by the way, been involved in Cyprus, that was my second engagement with operations – it was decided that Cypriot students would come under all sorts of bad influences in London at the LSE and so on, so it was thought best to ship them out to the provinces, so they sent them to Hull! (LAUGHS) And you can't imagine, if you wanted to radicalise them, that was the place to send them! Of course, because Peter Worsley was there, we got a lot of African students. I think it was the Ghanaian Foreign Minster came to Hull, and he wanted to be photographed with Ghanaian students, and the Ghanaian students were running all over the campus, trying to get away! The last thing they wanted was to be photographed with this guy! Hugh Gaitskell came to Hull, and addressed a rally, and he was challenged on nuclear weapons, and he made some comment like, "Do you really think that Britain should give up nuclear weapons, on its own?" And from the back of the platform a voice came, "Yes", and that was Peter [Worsley]! Gaitskell had a very rough time when he came to Hull. (pp. 20-21)

10: Stuck in the library

So, anyhow, there I was, at Hull. I'd done all the things, chasing the girls, getting drunk, all that sort of juvenilia, was out of my system, <u>and</u> at the same time, I'd saved enough money, before I came out of the Navy, to fund myself through university… So in the vacations I was just in the library, and I read and read and read and read, and it never occurred to me not to be doing this…

I don't think there were really any people I made very close friends with at Hull. And you can see why not, because when other people were making friends, I was stuck in the library! And I loved it! There was my little corner in the library. In the vacation I'd be in the library 9.30 in the morning, and I'd be there till it closed at five. And I set myself - this is the great thing of Naval discipline. I had a programme. On Monday, Tuesday, Wednesday, I was going to read sociology. On Thursday I was going to read books on social policy. Friday, it was going to be economics, which I had to do, and I found very boring, but I had my programme and I stuck to it. And so by that kind of systematic

programme of reading, I was able to read a hell of a lot, and very quickly. So my time as a student, was time as a student. (pp. 22-23)

11: Working with John Rex

I had read *Key Problems of Sociological Theory*, and I thought I would like to work with John Rex – if I could… It was the only post-War British book on sociological theory at that time… He was clearly Britain's leading writer on theory… So I wrote and said, "Any chance of working with you?" And some time later I had a letter from him, saying, "Can we meet some time?" So I met him at the Bamboo Coffee Bar under the railway bridge at Golders Green, and he said, "I've got this money from the Survey of Race Relations in Britain to do a social survey of an inner part of Birmingham, if you want to come and work with me, how about it?" And he started telling me all the things he wanted to do there, which was a kind of mixture of empirical data collecting, and participant observation. And then I, in all my brashness of youth, said, "This is all very interesting, but how does this tie in with the theoretical positions that I've read in *Key Problems of Sociological Theory*?" I subsequently discovered that that challenge to him became the basis of one of the chapters of *Race, Community and Conflict*…

So I went to Birmingham to work with him, whereupon he was appointed to the new Chair of Sociology, or Social Theory and Institutions, in Durham. So he was in Durham, and I was in Birmingham, as a brand-new recently graduated sociologist, doing this project…

Well, as you know, John is not the easiest person in the world to work with. I think it's felt that Sally Tomlinson and I were the two who were able to establish the best relationships with him. I think I only had one really flaming row with him, but that was after Sparkbrook. It was clearly an unequal relationship because he was a very distinguished sociologist and I was just a a new researcher. But he had almost - I sensed a slight respect for me, because as he's said many times since, he said, "You've got a nose for trouble." And I'm one of these people who doesn't hesitate to poke my nose in where it's clearly going to be very unwelcome, and where I'm going to discover things that

people would rather I didn't discover! So I was a fairly bold fieldworker, and I think he liked that, and I think he liked my kind of disciplined approach. (pp. 25-27)

We looked at one another's chapters. We took sole responsibility for our chapters, but then we read one another's work. On the whole, John didn't take terribly kindly to any critical comments on what he'd written, but then he never did, and I knew that, so that I normally just made suggestions… No, but we sat in our own rooms, writing our own chapters, and then occasionally met and discussed what we'd been writing.

What about working out the design of the book, was that a joint thing?

It was a joint thing, but John was clearly the senior partner. But he listened to me, I appreciated that… To some extent, John and I had our own separate theoretical thoughts. He clearly had very strong views on race relations, partly rooted in his South African experience. I was more willing to be led by the data. I just found Sparkbrook so fascinating, and I'd only recently graduated, and so I don't think I brought any particular theoretical armoury to it. It was that Sparkbrook, itself, set off, as I say, Durkheim and the Chicago School and so on, and Whyte, in my mind. (p. 43)

12: Framing questions: Malinowski

When I started off in Sparkbrook, and I think I mentioned *Street Corner Society*, but I think what I didn't mention, and it's very important, and has always stuck with me, was Malinowski's *Scientific Theory of Culture*. I don't know how that's rated nowadays, but I find when I'm, if you like, "doing sociology", I'm very often doing what he said. You encounter an organisation, and you say, "Well, what's the purpose of this organisation? What does it say it's here for? Who are its membership? What other functions does it have" - besides those which are in what Malinowski called "it's charter". And then, "What effects does it have?" So in terms of confronting some new situation, some new institution or organisation, I think those Malinowskian questions constitute a very very important aide memoir to get you started. (pp. 72-73)

13: Participant observation in an ethnically mixed community

It was fieldwork in an afternoon and evening, and then mornings typing up field notes in my office. I had that kind of routine, and I worked very hard, I have to say. I did a very long day's work…

So I was in and around Sparkbrook, talking to people, and then later on supervising students doing interview schedules. And I went to the pubs. The great thing about being a teetotaller is, of course, you can remember what went on in the pub! I had long conversations in pubs. I went to cafés.

I went, I think, to every single religious institution there, and I went to some outside Sparkbrook because, of course, the Sikhs in Sparkbrook went to the Gurdwara in Smethwick. I made contacts with people, friendly relations with them, and I'd say, "Oh", you know, "I've never been to a Gurdwara." I mean, "Do you think you could take me along?" "Oh yes!" they were eager to take me along. And so I went. I did the same with the mosque. And it was lovely. Sitting in the gallery in the Gurdwara in Smethwick, during the festivities, half way through the ceremonies my host leant across to me and said, "This makes me feel like I'm at home". And that's exactly what the sociologist wanted to hear from one of his informants! This is why he was here. The guy wasn't terribly religious, it was just like being at home. Then we had the big meal afterwards. … After the ceremonies, well, you go down to the basement, and they have this whacking great meal! And you all sit down at long tables and tuck in! It's tremendous! … (pp. 28-29)

I got caught up in a major street fight! (LAUGHS) I was in the particular part of Sparkbrook where there were, at the time, quite a lot of travellers who'd temporarily taken over some houses there. I never found out exactly what was going on, but quite a big fight broke out either between two sectors of the traveller community, or between the travellers and the Irish population – there was quite a big Irish settlement there – and I wouldn't call it a riot, but there were lots of people out on the street, and they were punching one another, and bricks and bottles were flying around. I heard this was going on, so I dashed down and was immediately stopped by a policeman who said, "Oh, you

can't go down there". I thought, "I'm going to have to get through here somewhere". So I took my jacket off, and turned it inside out, so I looked different, and had another go, and I got through the police cordon this time, and went and watched what was the end of this fracas, and I finished up hiding under a hedge with bottles and bricks flying over! Yeah, all in the life of a young sociologist! … And this is John's thing about, you know, "A nose for trouble". I got into the trouble! (p. 30)

In what sort of ways did you get to know the English?

Well, there was a woman in Braithwaite Road, in the middle of the minority settlement, who was constantly writing racist letters to the local paper, and so I went to see her, and got on quite friendly terms with her. She wasn't a wicked woman, she was very misguided! (LAUGHS) So I chatted to her, and got to meet one or two of her friends. I got to know the local vicar, because he was involved with the community, with the Sparkbrook Association; and the doctor, Dr. Barrow, who had lots of friends. I got to know people by meeting them on the streets, and there was an adventure playground – I think it was one of the first in Britain, in Sparkbrook – it was very innovative, you know, an adventure playground. And I knew the people running that, and so I met quite a few English kids, and then met their parents at the adventure playground. Where else did I meet English people? I met them in the churches. I met them in the Sparkbrook Labour Club, but that became increasingly Irish, but there were some old stalwart Brummies in the Labour Club….

But the thing about Sparkbrook, in those days, was that it was quite easy to meet people on the streets, you know, there were just a lot of people out and about, and you could say hello to somebody, you could fall in – particularly with British people – walk along beside them on the pavement and chat, and then just go off to do whatever else you were doing. So I didn't have any sort of strategy which said, "Right. Now I'm going to interview ten English origin people", you know, "Five women, five men". I just let it happen, and I think I met quite a lot of them that way.

And would people invite you in for a cup of tea?

The English, on the whole, not. No. The English are perhaps a bit more reserved. It was the minorities who were the most hospitable. No, I didn't enjoy any very close relations with English families in Sparkbrook. And I didn't experience much hostility either. I can't remember the name of the woman who used to write the letters now, but I rubbed along with her and she was typical of racists at the time. You got talking to her, and she was going on about all these West Indians and all the terrible things they did, and then you said, "But, look, your next door neighbours are West Indian". "Oh well, he's different. He's a real gent. He's a real gentleman".

It was very hard not to intervene. I intervened almost inadvertently really, because I remember talking to her, and she said how unfriendly and stand-offish the Pakistani men were, and they were really not very nice people at all, and so on, and she'd obviously tried to befriend them, and I said to her, "Look, these people have as much difficulty with your culture as you do with theirs". I said, "There are quite a few people, quite a few men, who migrated to Sparkbrook, who don't really know how to deal with women outside their family. They don't know how to relate to strange women"… I said, "It's not that you're having difficulty with them", I said, "they're having difficulty with you". "Oh!" she said, "I never thought of that!" … And I thought, "Oh well, now the participant observer has intervened". But, I couldn't not have that discussion with her…

I think I met my first West Indians through John Rex, who had met a young couple, the woman was a schoolteacher. That was the other way I met English people, by schoolteachers. And I started off with this young couple who'd actually just moved out of Sparkbrook to the suburbs, but they knew people in Sparkbrook still, and they provided me with an entrée to meet various people. And again, the churches were quite important there. But the Sparkbrook Association also had a West Indian clientele, including the people who were organising the Caribbean Football League. And so that gave me all sorts of ready-made contacts. Although I don't know anything about football, I could get them to talk to me about football, and how they played out inter-island rivalries on the football pitch. And then in the churches it was very straightforward to talk to them. Well, straightforward in the Methodist Church, because I'm a Methodist, and that all clicked. Some of the more Evangelical churches I found a bit tough-going, particularly when half

way through a service, people would say, "And would you like to say a few words to the congregation?" to which I normally said, "No thank you. Not today". …

Then there was the Irish, how did you get to know them?

Largely through the Sparkbrook Association. But there was also an Irish Association, and that was actually in Sparkhill, but it was right adjacent to Sparkbrook, and I occasionally went there to talk to people, a lot of whom came from County Clare, and there was a County Clare Association, and I used them to find me Irish people I could sit and chat to. I met quite a few Irish people through the Sparkbrook Association, and particularly through the lads who used to come - they were good value, the Irish teenagers. They were a bit wild, but they were okay.

The church, was that helpful?

Not really. I went, as I say, to every church and temple, and mosque in Sparkbrook, but the Catholic Church, the way in which Mass was conducted on Sunday was not conducive to finding respondents. The men all stood at the back of the church, and as soon as it was over, they rushed outside and lit up their fags and so on. The women inside often had children and there were other activities then going on. So it was easier for me to go to social events organised by the Church, and I did that from time to time.

You're making it sound as if I did a whole series of structured interviews. I didn't. I mean, I just spent my time meeting up with people, striking up casual - well, not casual, I was being calculating about it, but striking up conversations, chatting on the street, in the Clubs – the Irish Club, County Clare and so on – and having conversations with the people that I could find. And occasionally they would say, "Oh, you ought to meet my cousin", in which case I would. But it was a bit unstructured. I suppose it was a little bit like the anthropologist. …

I forget how I got to meet the Pakistanis! (LAUGHS) But this was where I actually developed a key informant – Mr. Khan – who was a Pashtun, and he'd been in the Army in the War. He was from North-West Territory. And he really thought he was a cut above

all the other Pakistanis, and he had a very strong view of the status hierarchy of the Pakistani community, and he was very near the top. And he used to talk. He said, "Oh, you don't want to talk to those people, they're domestic servant class". I said, "Yes I do actually want to talk to them". But he did introduce me to people. And he gave me quite a good commentary. He had this particular view of the social status structure of the Pakistani community, which was highly partial, very biased, but it gave me something to go out and test. I knew it couldn't be right, but you had something. I've often said to students, "It's better to have a bad idea on paper than a good idea in your head", you've got to have something to work on.

Then I met Pakistanis in the pubs, and from that I got introductions, and I became very friendly with a shop-keeper who, surprise, surprise, his name was Patel! He was the only person with whom I really maintained much contact after I left Sparkbrook. He had a daughter, he had three children… I became quite friendly with him, and he was important to me because one of the problems I had was talking to Pakistani women, partly because the women didn't want to talk to me, and partly because, of course, of their culture, strange men don't come and talk. Mr. Patel was a little bit more open than most, and I got invited to eat at his house, and that was marvellous, because I was able to talk to his wife about cooking – this is where I started learning Indian cooking. And he said, "Oh, you don't want to know about cooking". I said, "Yes I do". So he was sitting in the little living room, and I went into the kitchen, and talked to - she didn't have terribly good English, but we had a little conversation, and that was the beginning of me starting to talk to some of the women.

I met another wife, later on, who complained about her husband going to the pub. He didn't want to go back to Pakistan, because one of the things I said was, "Do you have this dream of going back one day, when you've made your fortune in Sparkbrook?" He said, "No". So I said, "Why not?" He said, "No pubs". (LAUGHS) And his wife didn't like him going out drinking. (pp. 32-36)

If there was a landlord dispute with a tenant – and there were plenty of those – people would come to me. And I'd say, "Well, actually, I'm the wrong person… I listened, but I very rarely tried to mediate because there were proper channels for dealing with this. But

it meant that I listened to both tenants and landlords… On the question of overcrowding, a lot of these Pakistani landlords didn't realise that children counted. So they didn't realise they'd overcrowded their houses, in law, because they only added up the adults, but when you added in the children, they were actually breaking the law. …

Of course, we became very interested in the landlords because they were providing the only housing that was really available for the large number of immigrants that were coming into Sparkbrook, but they were being punished for doing it. And for them, it solved one of their problems. They were Pakistani men who could club together to get the deposit on a house, and then that provided, as it were, free accommodation for them and their cousins, then the rest of the house they could pack with paying tenants who would then help pay off the mortgage. So there were a lot of Irish and West Indians and other Indians and Pakistanis who were very grateful for the accommodation that they provided, but it was a very very low standard. It was at the level of a room in a big house, with a shared gas stove on the landing. You can imagine the kind of conflicts over who used it last, and who cleaned it, and why wasn't it working and whose pot had boiled over on it, so there were endless disputes. So we got a chance to talk to disgruntled tenants, and to disgruntled landlords. It was the Pakistani men who invited us in much more often, you know, to have tea, and something to eat, so I often sat down and chatted with them in their overcrowded lodging houses. … (p. 39)

The other idea was just to listen to people's stories. I'd read the Chicago School stuff, and, I mean, Whyte just hung around, didn't he, with these people, and I thought, "Well, I'd better hang around", so I hung around! And if you'd asked me what I was doing, I was hanging around doing sociology. I didn't have a clear programme. I wouldn't send a post-graduate out now to do what I was doing, and they wouldn't do it. They'd say, "Well, what do you want me to do?" I'd say, "Hang around". That wouldn't do… But that's what I did! (p. 41)

14: Marginal men as a source for theory

The man in the Brewers' Arms was a really critical figure in our research. He was what the Chicago School would have called the "marginal man"… We went to this pub, the

Brewers' Arms, and it was mainly an Irish pub, but it was obviously quite a social centre because there were notices on the wall about, "So and So thanks the regulars for their wreath", on the death of her husband or whatever. There were darts matches and outings, and the barmaid clearly dispensed advice to any berated men about going home and looking after their wives. It wasn't just a market place for drink, it was a nice kind of social ambience. And they sang Irish songs. They had a microphone. It was a dreadful racket, but it was a very warm, nice kind of place.

We found in here this Englishman, who must have been in his late sixties, and he seemed always to have had slightly too much to drink, but not enough to be completely paralytic, and he was always trying to get to the microphone to sing the next Irish song, he very rarely made it, but when he did, he sung Irish songs. Well, we had a long chat with him, and he came from a Sparkbrook family, and he'd been in the Army during the War, and all his reference points had disappeared – his family had either moved away or died out; his Regiment had been disbanded and no longer had reunions; the British Legion had closed down; and he was gradually kind of losing his grip on any society. He was becoming isolated. The Brewers' Arms was his local, and he was trying, clearly, to re-invent himself as an honorary Irishman, to become part of that culture, and he was clinging on by the skin of his teeth. His effectiveness in re-inventing himself was constantly being undermined by the fact that he was drinking in the Brewers' Arms, and he was really an incredibly marginal person, and you couldn't say whether he would make it back into a supportive network and society, or whether he'd just become a down and out.

So how was he helpful, though, for the research?

Well, you just imagine sitting talking to somebody explaining their marginality. It was a case study of a zone of transition. The West Indian schoolteacher I started off with was the absolute opposite. They had used Sparkbrook as a stepping-stone, they got a cheap house. Now they were in a nice house in the suburbs, you know, had a job, you know, respectable occupation, they had moved on. They had been marginal, perhaps, in Sparkbrook, but they'd moved into the mainstream.

This guy had been in the mainstream – family, Army, British Legion – and now he was sliding out. One started thinking about the work of the Chicago School and the "marginal man". He was right on the fringe. You could see him teetering along the fringe. So he was a fascinating person. Maybe that particular interview didn't generate a lot of data, but by Heavens, he was theoretically stimulating! You walked out of that pub and your brain was in theoretical overdrive!

I used to say to John that when I was in Sparkbrook I was always thinking theory, and when I was back in my office, trying to do the theory, I wanted to get back into Sparkbrook. But Sparkbrook was a very Durkheimian experience. I kept on asking the question, "What is holding this together?" Or, "To what extent is this being held together, and by what?" Because Durkheim was working in a society that was in a state of virtual disintegration, and certainly catastrophic change, so was Sparkbrook…. So the man in the Brewers' Arms may not have generated reams and reams of data, but he was a tremendous intellectual challenge. (pp. 36-38)

15: The power of Durham women

I had looked at the miners, and I'd looked at the men, I didn't really go in intending, or prepared, to look closely enough at the women. And what gradually emerged from getting – I mean, this was five years in and around these communities, going to chapel on Sunday, mixing with people, I got to know them quite well – was that when you went back in the history, pre-First World War, the driving force were the women Suffragists – the women who were campaigning for votes for women. I mean, I met a woman who tried to burn down the local railway station! She told me how she did it! Lucky she didn't burn herself down!

They'd been played cat and mouse with by the police, and all the rest of it. I think they had been very much the inspiration for the ILP, and for the pacifists in the First World War. Now, not only that, not only had the women been the inspiration, and had they shown the men how to resist, but the police and the authorities had learnt how to deal with dissidents, as a result of their experience with the Suffragettes…

But I became very aware of the enormous power of those women, and what the men had learnt from the radical women, and I couldn't help thinking of my mother when I met those radical women… I was going back, if I could go back to 1965/'66, and start again in the Deerness Valley, I would spend a lot more time talking to the older women. (pp. 48-49)

16: Spotting community myth

A particular population actually develops its own story about itself, which is shared in common, [but] the unwary researcher may think they're getting an individual's account. Now, there had been a very scandalous event in the Methodist population in the 1920s, involving a local preacher and a girl in the choir. It was kind of shock horror, and even in the 1960s people were a bit reluctant to talk about it, and I just wondered whether there were relatives still around. I don't know. But when I did broach this subject, I got the same account, people told me the same things, and I thought, "Good!", you know, "I'm getting the story of what happened". And one day I was going home on the 44 bus, and I'd been interviewing a woman from the Methodist Chapel, and she had told me about this event, and I thought, "Now, that's odd! This woman can't be old enough to remember that event. Perhaps she's heard it from somebody". Anyhow, later on, in my archival research in one of the Durham newspapers, in the 1920s I found a little report about these scandalous events in this village, and the newspaper report was word for word what all the individual people had told me in their interviews. So what I was getting from the village was not necessarily first-hand accounts of people who were involved or engaged, but they were feeding back to me press reports which they had read, or had been passed down to them. And that was a very sharp cautionary tale, for a still quite a young researcher. Wow! I thought I was triangulating, "Everybody was telling me the same story, so it must be true!" Well, it probably was true, but they were not independent accounts. It was the agreed version. (pp. 50-51)

17: Divided community: Peterhead

I did a study of a small town, and it was a moot point whether it was a community. It was only a community in certain circumstances… One of the big fissures was between fisher folk and the rest, and the fisher folk were rather looked down on by "respectable" people in Peterhead – they were seen as being rather gauche and "not our kind of people at all". And then one Sunday they did the televised Sunday Service from the Parish Church in Peterhead, which was the church of the elite, and what did they do for this televised service? They decorated the church with nets and fishing floats and all sorts of symbols of fishing, and they asserted that this was a fishing community bound together by the hazards of fishing and the sea. And these were people who wouldn't be seen dead with the fisher folk! But when they presented themselves to the outside world, they usurped the symbols of the most despised part of the population. But that was kind of beautiful.

Then there were conflicts over the oil industry, because the oil industry brought in lots of American companies, and on the whole, British people don't really trust the Yanks, as it were. Peterhead people aren't sure about people from Fraserburgh! So when Americans come into town with money, and accents like you see on the television, they're very suspicious. A lot of the business population in Peterhead saw these Americans as fly-by-night - not quite as gangsters, but wide boys and so on, "No good will come of it". And then they said, "Yeah, look at all these relationships developing. Some of these Americans have - some women in the town have run off with Americans". The trouble was, the women would have run off years before, but they didn't have the opportunity! And, more importantly, the oil industry started offering wages that the local industries couldn't offer, and they felt there was this terrible competition for wages…

Then you get the important role of the "marginal man" again. I'll use his real name, I'm sure he won't mind. Nearly everybody in Peterhead seems to be called "Buchan" or "Strachan". But what about Ronnie Ferrari! He was an Italian immigrant who owned a fish and chip shop! And he bought a bar, and he stood behind his bar, and he listened to oil men talking, and he heard what they needed – everything from nuts, bolts, and flange plates, to women! Ronnie decided there was an opportunity here. He was an entrepreneur, he became a supplier to the oil industry, both formally and informally. He

became a millionaire. He later lost the lot. He used to ride round town on a bicycle, and he finished up driving a Ferrari! And he finished up actually on a bicycle again. But wasn't that fascinating, that here was the "marginal man": he was a Catholic, an Italian, and he was the one who made it when the oil came.

The economic boom in Peterhead was also attributable to the fishing boom. Fishing was immensely profitable at that time, and people were buying bigger and bigger boats, and that was creating problems for the Plymouth Brethren… The Brethren believe "you shouldn't be yoked with unbelievers". So the boats tended to be owned by co-religionists… But as they had to fish in deeper and deeper waters, they needed bigger and bigger boats, which meant you had to have more capital and larger crews. So how could you keep it within the community of believers? Well, ultimately, you couldn't. So some of them went out of fishing altogether. Others bit the bullet and went to sea with people who weren't members of their sect… I was told that, on some of the ships, in the mess room, they made a saw cut through the middle of the mess table, to avoid commensality with people who weren't members of your faction of the Brethren. So there were these incredible conflicts within the Brethren.

And there was a big factory in town – it was Crosse and Blackwell canning factory – which employed a lot of women who were moderately poorly-paid, and the USDAW tried to unionise them, with limited success, because the menfolk told the women that they weren't allowed to join in organisations with non-believers. So it was very hard to Unionise. Anyhow, eventually USDAW started campaigning for equal pay in the Crosse and Blackwell's factory, the women, who were mainly from the Brethren families, virtually came out on strike <u>against</u> equal pay. They said the man's role was that of breadwinner, and if women got equal pay, it would diminish the role of the man. You imagine, in the middle of the Feminist revival, in sociology, encountering these kind of attitudes. …

Everybody I interviewed was keen that I should dish the dirt on other people in the town. … I've said, many times in public, that Peterhead was a community held together by a network of mutual hatred… "I may not like you, but we both hate somebody else, so that unites us", that was Peterhead! Everybody hated everybody else! (LAUGHS) But

because they did, it kind of united them. And everybody wanted to take me on one side and make sure I knew what So and So had really done! (pp. 64-67)

18: Discrimination against women: the oil industry

Women in the North Sea Oil Industry? Well, now, that resulted in the law being changed. As a result of that book, or that report, the Sex Discrimination Act 1975, was extended to the Continental Shelf. The government had extended the tax law to the Continental Shelf in three days. It took them a very long time to extend the Sex Discrimination Act!

But that was quite interesting, because in the Norwegian Sector, we knew a lot of women were being employed offshore, and the companies – some of whom were also operating in the British Sector – were actually adapting their shift arrangements to cater for families, so that couples without children could, if they wanted, work offshore together, or couples who didn't want to work offshore together could be given opposite shifts and time. It was properly - if not family-friendly, at least it recognised that people had families. In the British Sector they just said, "We don't employ families. We employ hands" - or as they put it in one case, "white niggers".

But we couldn't really get access to offshore, they were very suspicious of sociologists, you can imagine! And the problem was, how many women worked offshore in the British Sector? Well, actually, the answer was zero. Women did go offshore, but they didn't stay, they just went out on day trips, and we found the easiest way to count them was just to send a research assistant to Aberdeen airport, and they could just count them going offshore and coming back on again! …

So with that work, I went round universities interviewing final year and recently graduated geology students, female geology students, and their teachers in the university. The other category we looked at were cooks. We thought we'd take the two ends of the occupational spectrum. Now, the cooks were easy. There were no cooks employed offshore, no catering companies were even going to try. So we concentrated on the geologists… The thing about geology students is a lot of them are very outdoor people, they go canoeing and mountaineering and hiking, because they like the environment. So I

found the women geology students a very interesting, engaging bunch of people. I interviewed up and down the country and … I was getting the story of the extreme discrimination against women who wanted to work offshore, and the fact that the kind of experience that you needed offshore was absolutely essential to your promotion prospects in geology…

Traditionally, women have done the geophysics work back at base, and that's not the route to promotion – that's a dead end. And women were still being directed into this. Then I discovered that a lot of university lecturers and professors were adopting very paternalistic attitudes towards their female students, and trying to protect them from discrimination by directing them towards employment where they knew women would be taken on. So they were actually directing them towards the occupations that had the lowest career prospects. They weren't doing that deliberately, they were almost doing it out of the kindness of their hearts, but they were actually just contributing to the discrimination against women.

When we got into talking to the companies, we found that – as onshore with the construction work – [it was] tied up with all this business of sub-contracting. Everybody said, "Well, it's not me, but it's our sub-contractors". And there was some truth in that… There was also really brutal discrimination against women. My colleague, Peter Whybrow, interviewed some managers who said they were never going to employ women, but they did sometimes interview women because they had to. And what they used to do was to play a game, and they took bets on how long it took to reduce the woman candidate to tears in the interview. I told this story when the report was published, to a group of managers, and there was one guy there who said, "This is outrageous! If anybody in my company behaved in that way, they'd be out the door before they could draw breath". It was his company! …

The Report was published the day after Indira Ghandi was assassinated, so it got no press coverage except from the *Daily Mail*. Now, the *Daily Mail* reporter had a long session with me after the press conference, and he was very careful he got everything down properly. When the story appeared the next day, it was clearly written to make me and the EOC to look absolute fools. They had doubled the cost of the project, and doubled the

length of time it took to produce it, and basically said, "Why are we wasting taxpayers' money, spending all this time proving something that everybody knows anyhow?" So I phoned up the reporter and said, "Look. What are you playing at? I saw you write it down". He said, "I'm terribly sorry". He said, "I wrote that up properly", he said, "but my editor thought it would make a better story if he changed the facts". So the only press coverage I got was a send up in the *Daily Mail*. However, the law was still changed. (pp. 67-70)